

ITALIAN SUPPORT

During the Spanish Civil War, the Italian Savoia-Marchetti SM.81 bomber was used in support of Franco's Nationalist troops and in attacks on cities. The SM.81 shown here is escorted by Fiat CR.32 biplane fighters.

based on its experience in Spain, was that in the long run they were more likely to stiffen popular resistance than to undermine morale. This was not the conclusion drawn by most political and military leaders worldwide. What people expect is what they see, and Guernica in particular was widely interpreted as confirming the expectation of a swift devastation of cities in the early stages of any major war.

Theories of war

Meanwhile in 1937 Japan had invaded China, giving another demonstration of the effectiveness and frightfulness of air power. Cities such as Shanghai and Nanking were subjected to



THE DESTRUCTION OF GUERNICA



ON MONDAY APRIL 26, 1937, it was market day in the small but ancient Basque town of Guernica. At around 4:30 in the afternoon, when the town was at its most crowded, 43 aircraft of the Condor Legion – Heinkel He 111 medium bombers, He 51 fighters, and Ju 52 transport aircraft used as bombers – launched the first wave of an attack that lasted more than three hours. Strafing and dropping high-explosive bombs and incendiary devices, the German aircraft destroyed about half of the town.

A Basque Catholic priest, Alberto Onaindia, described the apocalyptic scene: “Five minutes did not elapse without the sky’s being black with German planes. The planes descended very low, the machine-gun fire tearing up the woods and roads, in whose gutters, huddled together, lay old men, women, and children... Fire enveloped the whole city. Screams of lamentation were

CONDOR LEGION

This postcard image shows the flags of Spain and the Condor Legion paraded side by side. The Condor Legion, which attacked Guernica, consisted of the best airmen from Hitler’s developing Luftwaffe.



heard everywhere, and the people, filled with terror, knelt, lifting their hands to heaven...”

Foreign journalists were on the scene the following day and filed graphic descriptions of the carnage and destruction. The Nationalists and Germans for a long time denied that Guernica had been bombed at all. They later more plausibly argued that Guernica had been a valid military target, since it housed reserve troops and was a major crossroads. But the Republicans won the propaganda war, establishing Guernica as a symbol of the evils both of Nazism and of terror bombing from the air. Artist Pablo Picasso, who had been commissioned to produce a large work for the Spanish Republic’s pavilion at the Paris World Fair, created an iconic painting that was to prove the event’s most lasting memorial.

SYMBOL OF DESTRUCTION

Guernica was reduced to ruins when 100,000lb (45,000kg) of explosives were dropped by German bombers in what was widely regarded as the deliberate terror bombing of a civilian target. Up to 1,600 people may have perished.